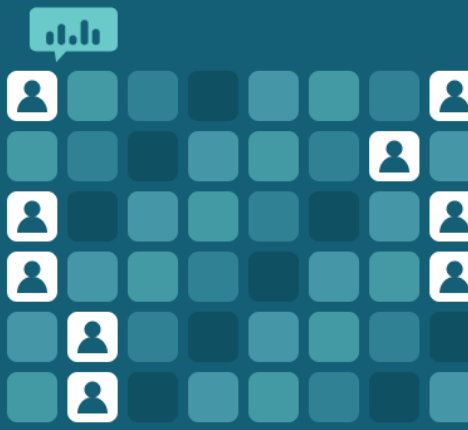
Place-based data training

Activities workbook

Module 3.3: Evidence development



This training brings together practical guidance for using data in place-based work. It draws on PLACE and Seer Data's work alongside place-based initiatives across Australia.

The training covers the journey many place-based initiatives go on – from finding and accessing data to sharing it, making sense of it with community and using it to support local decisions and action.

Who is it for?

It is designed for people working in or supporting place-based initiatives. You might be new to working with data or already using and managing data as part of your everyday rhythm.

How to use this workbook

Throughout the training, you'll find opportunities to reflect on your work and consider how the ideas and tools apply in your place or initiative. This workbook brings together the activities for this module.

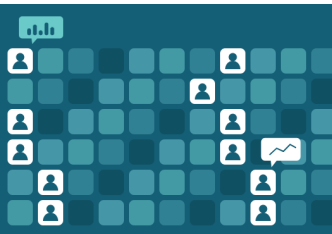
You can work through the training from beginning to end, or choose the modules most relevant to your role, experience and current work. We recommend starting with Welcome to place-based data training. You can return to other sections as you need them.

You can also connect with others doing the training to ask questions, share what you're learning and learn from their experience on PLACExCHANGE at **pxc.placeaustralia.org**.

A collaboration between

PLACE
Partnerships for Local Action & Community Empowerment

Seer
Data & Analytics



Understanding & using data together

Module

3.3 Evidence development

Section 1	Apply systems thinking to frame the challenge	2 activities
Section 2	Develop an evidence-based community story	2 activities
Section 3	The Understanding, Measurement, Evaluation and Learning (UMEL) framework	2 activities

Try this now: map the factors behind one local issue

Apply Apply to your place 1

Take one issue you are working on. In the table below, name a few factors that affect it, such as a policy, a funding rule, a service practice or a community strength.

For each factor, note how it affects the issue, and whether that influence pushes the issue up (+) or down (–). This is the start of a factor map.

A factor that affects the issue	How it affects the issue	Direction (+ or –)

Example you can use

No live issue right now? Use this one: young people in a town are disengaging from school.

Try this now: look beneath one event with the Iceberg Model

Apply Apply to your place 2

Take one visible event or problem in your work. Use the table to move down through the levels of the iceberg, discussed earlier: the pattern over time, the structures that shape it, and the beliefs or assumptions that hold it in place.

You do not need every box filled in; the aim is to look below the surface.

Iceberg level	What I notice or would ask about this event
Event (what we see)	
Patterns and trends (over time)	
Structures (what is causing the pattern)	
Mental models (beliefs holding it in place)	

Example you can use

No live example right now? Use this one: residents say they feel less connected to their community than they did a decade ago.

Try this now: map what you already know about one community goal

Apply Apply to your place 1

Take one concern or goal that matters to a community you work with. In the table, note what data already exists, who owns or controls it, whose voice might be missing, and how well it fits your place. This is the start of a data map.

The community goal or concern	Data that already exists	Who owns or controls it	Whose voice is missing, and how well it fits your place

Example you can use

No live goal right now? Use this one: families want children to arrive at school ready to learn.

Try this now: draft the outline of a case for change

Apply Apply to your place 2

Take one issue a community has raised. Use the table to sketch the four parts of a case for change in a few words each. This is a first draft to test and revise with community, not a finished document.

Part of the case for change	In a few words
What is happening now (the baseline)	
Why this matters here	
What happens if nothing changes	
What success would look like	

Example you can use

No live issue right now? Use this one: there is nowhere safe for teenagers to gather after school.

Try this now: design one part of UMEL with community in mind

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Take one change a community wants to see. In the table, note how you would know the change was happening, and one simple, safe way you could notice or track it with community. Keep it manageable and respectful.

The change community wants to see	How we would notice it was happening	A simple, safe way to track it

Example you can use

No live example right now? Use this one: people in the community feel more connected and able to support one another.

Try this now: turn commitment into action

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Think about a piece of work where you want UMEL to take hold. In the table, name one action you could start now, one longer-term commitment that needs ongoing support, and who needs to be involved to make it happen.

One immediate action	One longer-term commitment	Who needs to be involved

Example you can use

No live example right now? Use this one: a partnership wants to show funders how a youth program is making a difference.